

On the contradictions of assigning the symbolic value known as art to images and gestures

Sobre as contradições da atribuição do valor simbólico conhecido como arte a imagens e gestos

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Abstract

This essay sets out from questions about processes of assigning symbolic value, chiefly what is called art, in order to discuss the relevance and impact of image production in contemporary times. It is written in the more informal format of the essay, using the first person singular as narrator, in order to make clear the specificity of the author's place of speech and how important the recognition of that place is if one is to propose a discussion with a certain depth on a controversial and subjective subject.

The text articulates arguments from established theorists in the field of Art History, such as Jonathan Crary and his critique of the more current narrative about the relevance and origins of the modern art movement at the end of the nineteenth century, but it also underlines the importance of less traditionalist fields of study which question the leading role of the concept of art in theoretical reflection on images, such as Cultural Studies.

Finally, the author brings in international and Brazilian examples, and personal experiences, in order to contextualise the process of assigning and recognising artistic value, which is debated in terms of its possible contribution to the creation of cultural projects.

Keywords

symbolic value, cultural studies, image, market

Abstract (the author's own English version, as printed in the original)

This essay departs from questions about procedures for allocating symbolic value, especially the value known as art, to discuss relevance and impact of image creation in contemporary culture. It is written in the informal essay format, using the first person singular as narrator, to make clear the specificity of the speech place of the author and how relevant is the recognition of such place to propose a discussion with a certain depth on a controversial subject.

The text articulates theoretical arguments from established scholars in the Art History field, as Jonathan Crary and his criticism of the mainstream narrative about the significance and origins of the modern art movement, but also stresses the importance of less traditionalists fields of study, who question the role of the art concept in theoretical reflection on images, such as the

Cultural Studies.

Finally, the author brings international and Brazilian examples, altogether with personal experiences, to contextualize the process of award and recognition of artistic value, which is discussed in terms of their possible contribution to the creation of cultural projects.

Keywords / Palavras clave / Mots-clés: symbolic value, cultural studies, image, art market

What is the relevance and the impact of treating visual expressions as art?

I begin this essay with a rather loaded question, but one that is a personal dilemma and at the same time a necessary doubt for anyone working in the creation of images and objects that exist mainly because of their symbolic value and not because of a use value.

Art History's own internal questioning, as well as the questioning brought by theorists of what has come to be called Visual Studies, or even Cultural Studies, is extremely pertinent to the question posed. The latter are essential references precisely because they consider visual culture in a broader way than Art History does, without giving pride of place in their analyses to the objects and images recognised as artistic. Considering the explosion of images in the twentieth century, or even the anthropological conceptual turns that took place in the same century, how far has the relation of production of objects and images changed with the constant technological revolutions and then the media ones? The concept of art as it developed out of Renaissance Europe seems far too limited to guide an understanding of the visual expressions of our era.

The historical narrative focused on the concept of art has been steadily weakened. In Jonathan Crary's book *Techniques of the Observer*, published in 1990, the well-known art historian from Columbia University argues that the current narrative about the importance of modernism in transforming the ways of seeing and producing images is heavily exaggerated and blind to other processes that had been under way since the eighteenth century. He argues that our visual understanding is always shaped by the apparatuses that create and transmit images, as well as by the epistemological conceptions of an epoch — ideas Crary exemplifies by stressing the impossibility of a theory of pure visibility in the eighteenth century. The author shows how key concepts that were loudly brandished as novelties by the pre-modernists at the turn of the nineteenth into the twentieth century had already been published in almost the same words by scientists at the beginning of the nineteenth century who were reflecting on the workings of human vision, above all on the physiology of the eye — as is the case with Maurice Dennis's famous saying that painting is above all coloured patches juxtaposed on a surface. Such research does not seek to invalidate modernism, nor to posit a precedence of science over art; rather, the author focuses a great deal on eighteenth-century philosophical debates and on how they were essential in changing the course of scientific research. What is pertinent about this book for the doubt posed here is how insufficient it is to isolate the expressions recognised as art from a broader context of cultural debate and visual production if one wants to understand the history of art itself.

If I comment on Jonathan Crary's work, it is because, as a visual artist with a passion for theory who works with art and new technologies, this researcher matters a great deal to me. He was one of my great references and one of the spurs for me to start taking an interest in algorithmic

images as a way of transforming painting's own approach to public space. His work already reveals a very particular path within the discipline of Art History itself. But such questioning of art's privileged place among the manifestations of, and reflections on, visibility was addressed far more directly by Cultural Studies. One of the main points of that field of research is precisely a care for the place of speech (*lugar de fala*), the context, and therefore the time and space of the scholar. There is a very great difference between speaking about art in a country seen as central in our financial and material hierarchy of the world and speaking in a peripheral country, or speaking from different social classes. All the more so a country or a social group that identifies itself as peripheral, that organises itself in a constant attempt to import other people's models because it believes they must somehow be superior to local creations.

One need only look at the curriculum of most History faculties in Brazil — in my case Art History — to recognise the idiosyncrasy of living in a mixed-race country, where 50 per cent of the population currently declares itself black and where so many people are of indigenous, Arab and other ancestry, and yet almost all the authors on the compulsory reading lists of the courses are white Europeans or North Americans. Clearly less attention is given to histories and theories of African, Asian or even Latin American origin. Even so, as a personal experience, I should recall that the Art History course at UERJ, as I knew it, was one of the most progressive in the field, with compulsory subjects in anthropology, a critical history of institutions and others, which did a great deal to contest the traditional notions of art that are still in force. It is not a question of starting to avoid the great Western research institutions as theoretical references, but of recognising the power relations involved in discourse, since these directly influence the production of interpretative analyses of cultures.

The very concept of art, and still more that of the museum or the white cube of the exhibition, are ideas that make no sense in other contexts — for example, the study of Yoruba mural painting, which, like so many other cultural manifestations, does not distinguish the aesthetic value of its activities from religious symbolic value, or even from a cosmovision concerning the passage of time in that society. Ideas such as Roger Fry's, with his narratives (very much based on the theories of pure visibility) that separate art from what would be the more general context of life, as if both could have their own histories and occasionally draw close to one another, would simply not have been conceivable outside the West until a few decades ago. The Frenchman André Malraux, in his book *O museu imaginário* [The Imaginary Museum], which deals above all with how far contact with photographic reproductions of works of art alters our understanding of them, was already saying in 1947 that to other cultures the juxtaposition of works of very different origins and outside their contexts, as carried out by museums, would look like an out-of-tune symphony. Even so, museological and academic institutions are proliferating all over the world, just as there is more and more of a global art market — but in the course of this process the very notions of museum, of university and of art turn into other things.

To what extent do our cultural institutions go on reproducing models that are not adapted to our contexts? Cultural Studies itself, Visual Studies, Image Studies, still have their leading figures among thinkers from central countries, chiefly divided between the Anglo-Saxons and Continental Europe, even if there is currently a much more open dialogue with thinkers from

around the globe. Nicholas Mirzoeff, a Briton and one of the great names in Visual Studies, in an interview with Inés Dussel for the Argentine journal *Propuesta Educativa*, shows himself quite attentive to the criticisms made by Latin American journals of his theory that the seventeenth century, with its large-scale slave monocultures, was a key moment for thinking about transculture and about processes of globalisation of media and forms of control that preceded Jeremy Bentham's thought. After all, the Latin Americans argued that 1492 would be a far more relevant date in terms of a landmark and a rupture, and Mirzoeff simply agreed with the criticism. In the same interview the British author stresses at several points the role of the internet as a truly global medium, which now does not even have most of its content in English but only 30 per cent. In his words:

for the first time in history, we have a global medium that users can determine as much as its producers¹

The internet would be able to function as a coordinator and equaliser of content sharing far more powerful than the media of the twentieth century, and for that reason would have a very distinctive political impact, one that escapes the traditional institutional controls of the Nation State — but which nevertheless, as so many other thinkers and the whistleblower Edward Snowden have shown, also has forms of surveillance very different from those of earlier media, and dangerous ones too, which still recall Bentham's Panopticon model in the privileged vision and power of control of those who can access other people's data.

The emergence of image and video sharing on the internet seems to dispense with the validation of the symbolic value known as art, or with the validation of any institutionalised power, in order to grow and go viral. Would it be relevant for an image that goes viral on the great network to be recognised as artistic? What would such a title add to its power of influence? Perhaps the most important thing in beginning to answer such questions is to think about who assigns the value of art to a given cultural creation, and how it is assigned. Recalling a case that even predates the internet, but which is interesting because some decades have passed since it began and one can therefore watch it unfold: Robert Crumb produces comics and music, and his work gained visibility after the launch of his comic book, seen as underground, entitled *Zap Comix*, in 1968. The world of comics, *banda desenhada* or *revistas em quadrinhos* (a name that already sounds pejorative in Portuguese, as it carries the connotation of being aimed at a child audience), has its own history in the twentieth century and is more closely tied to publishing and illustration than to the debates of art institutions. Although this author has enjoyed great international renown for decades, at the 2013 Venice Biennale the original drawings for his book entitled *Genesis*, published in 2009, appeared in the conventional exhibition format, framed and with explanatory labels. His acceptance within the contemporary art world is much more recent than his international renown as a comics artist, so I ask myself whether such acceptance — coming to hold the title of artist — is one of the most relevant aspects of his career or a secondary one. Would it not be far more consequential that his works have been published in dozens of languages and sold millions of copies, and that they are influential in various groups debating contemporary culture, than his presence in major art centres through exhibitions of originals — centres that seem to insist on an appreciation based on the auratic character of a particular object? Seeing originals is always captivating for Crumb's fans, but the exhibitions seem secondary in his trajectory.

Robert Crumb (1943–) *Mr. Natural*, 1977 Robert Crumb Collection, Philadelphia (Source – http://www.crumbproducts.com/pages/books_comics.html)

Or again, moving to a Latin American, Brazilian example, it is worth recalling the case of São Paulo's *Pixação* or *Pichação* [the city's distinctive form of tagging], which has its origins in anarcho-punk movements, in gangs demonstrating power over territories, and in young people wanting to compete with advertising and escape a feeling of anonymity. In 2012, at the invitation of the Polish curator and artist Artur Zmijewski, a group of *pixadores* from the city of São Paulo took part in the 7th Berlin Biennale, which had political demonstrations as its theme and was entitled "Forget Fear". The *pixadores* did not accept the format of workshop and painting on hoardings proposed by the Biennale, and decided instead to climb a church and tag it, which drove the event's organisers to despair. Shortly afterwards, the Polish curator threw a glass of water at the *pixadores* during a heated argument, and one of them, Djan Cripta, retaliated by throwing a bucket of yellow paint over the curator. From then on, Djan gained even more visibility and gave a number of interviews in which he defends *pixação* as art and says that it is one of the most interesting manifestations of contemporary art because its strength lies in transgression². Djan criticises what he calls graffiti as mere beautification of the city, without critical power; he nevertheless argues that artists should live by selling their art on the specialist market, without entering into debates about how far the art market itself, based on the purchasing power of less than 0.1 per cent of the world's population, is contradictory in relation to the transgressions of the masses who live in the poor peripheries of the great urban centres (where a good part of the *pixadores* come from). Would the recognition of *Pixação* as art be something empowering for its political position? Would this recognition, over time, make its production better regarded socially? Or, on the contrary, if it is based on transgression, would it not lose its symbolic value once it is legitimated and well regarded, since it would no longer be transgressive? Who has an interest in valuing a transgressive aesthetic expression? A specialist art market, theorists, the inhabitants of the great urban centres, the public authorities who spend money erasing the tags, artists? Until the moment when some other activity comes to seem more radical? Would the search for recognition as art for such transgressive activities not be a continuation of modernism's ideal of the "new", always needing to go further in order to keep the power of estrangement that they claim as one of the essences of art?

I believe it is too early to answer such questions, especially in a case as recent as the valorisation of *pichação* in Brazil. What interests me in this account is the discrepancy of approaches, in the case of a major art institution, the Berlin Biennale, and of other theorists and artists who stress the symbolic force of a particular cultural activity, *Pixação*. It makes clear how far the recognition of artistic value is something extremely bound up with self-proclamation, or with a recognition based on critical theories of culture, or else with institutions that have the power to legitimate discourses, or indeed with the interests and processes of a particular market — and all these instances frequently disagree among themselves.

Djan Cripta (1985–) *Pixo*, (2012) Djan's personal archive, with photographs of his *pixações*, São Paulo, Brazil. Source: <https://catracalivre.com.br/sp/arte-e-design/indicacao/o-pixo-e-o-que-tem-de-mais-conceitual-na-arte-contemporanea-hoje/>

So, again: is it worthwhile, and why, to treat visual expressions as art? With such a subjective question, I intend to end this essay by turning once more to a personal experience. For some years I have been making mural paintings in the port district of Rio de Janeiro, mainly in the place known as Pedra do Sal, a historical and religious monument listed as heritage by INEPAC in 1984 (it is a rock with a stairway carved by slaves that opens onto a small square where many musical events and parties take place). It is a place of great importance, above all for the history of the African occupation of the Americas, since it lies in the area of the old slave complex that received more enslaved people than any other on the continent between the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. Many descendants of enslaved Africans went on living in the district, where there is also one of the first favelas in Brazil. Pedra do Sal is an important space as a religious sanctuary of candomblé, with Xangô as its orixá, as well as being home to the Comunidade Remanescente do Quilombo da Pedra do Sal [Remaining Community of the Pedra do Sal Quilombo]. This quilombo obtained its recognition from the Fundação dos Palmares only in the twenty-first century, a few years ago, and is still engaged in a land dispute over properties around Pedra do Sal which supposedly belonged to the Venerável Ordem Terceira, which has owned countless properties in the city since colonial times³. As with so many political processes in the city of Rio de Janeiro, there is an extremely confused and complicated history involving quilombolas, illegal occupations, drug trafficking, residents of the neighbourhood, the religious order and the public authorities. After years of disputes, 2016 was to be marked by attempts at reconciliation, chiefly because joint work was needed to complete the candidacy of the Valongo Wharf Archaeological Site for Unesco Material Heritage status, on top of the Olympic Games and the end of the works of the urban reform known as "Porto Maravilha".

When I began painting at Pedra do Sal, in 2010, I did not even know the quilombo existed, much less about the territorial disputes. There was nothing on the site itself to inform anyone about it (some discreet plaques have been installed since then). I painted without formal authorisation, on a listed historical site, simply because there was a white wall and the residents seemed pleased with the idea of having elaborate figurative paintings there. I painted life-size people who might have lived there, connected to the history of the district, despite my evident ignorance of other historical processes of that same space. Since one of the quilombolas liked the work, it stayed up for some years, and I ended up growing closer to the quilombo and to other local cultural groups. In 2014 I redid the mural of Pedra do Sal itself, this time in dialogue with the quilombolas and working as coordinator of the painting with other local artists. This mural came to be used by the quilombo as a marker of their presence on that site. In 2016 we proposed together another project, on a larger scale, of collaborative mural paintings at the site, this time attempting a different iconographic reference, studying the mural paintings of Yoruba sanctuaries as a way of respecting the religious importance of the space. However, if it were to become too clear that the project's final paintings have religious meanings, this could bring to the surface the conflicts with the Ordem Terceira and still more with the radical evangelical groups that are growing so much in the city. For that reason, we proposed two levels of reading for the project: for initiates it would be a kind of memorial and sanctuary of African matrix; to everyone else we say it is an artistic project, at most a memorial, that draws on references from African art.

Projeto Sankofa [Sankofa Project] (2016) Coordinated by Vanessa Rosa and Felipe Carvalho.

Pedra do Sal, Rio de Janeiro

Being the coordinator of such a project was more complicated than expected, considering that the scale of the murals is fairly modest (something close to 120 square metres). But with so much visibility in the port zone of Rio de Janeiro, which received many new murals during the Olympics even though none of the others turned to the history of the district, the tension of working in public space was far above normal. Even though I had been invited by the president of the quilombo, I was more than once challenged about being white and being in a symbolic space of black people, and I was even told that there could be no white people in such a project. There were also objections from residents who cared about the earlier paintings on that wall, even though it was in a terrible state: the paintings were mostly faded, and the walls suffer from serious damp. Most of the paintings on the site were still from a project I had coordinated in 2011 — after all, there had been no further whole-façade projects in that space apart from the initiatives I took part in and led. Nevertheless, being exposed in public space carrying out an independent project, which was funded with only 7,000 reais raised in a crowdfunding campaign, we were open to everyone's criticisms and other opinions. Or at least, there would have been no way of avoiding them.

Some of the objections were pertinent, even if I consider them exaggerated. I recognise that it is essential for black people to be the protagonists in actions that set out to speak openly about the Afro-Brazilian matrix and its demands for representation. Almost everyone else involved in the project was black and lived in the port district; we even decided that I should share the coordination of the project with another artist, Felipe Carvalho, who was brought up on Morro da Conceição itself. The president of the quilombo himself repudiated the criticisms of the presence of white people in the project, asking why the critics who frequented Pedra do Sal had never approached the quilombo or helped to create joint projects there. Making collective projects independently without access to capital is always quite difficult, but it is necessary in the case of a proposal that sets itself up as a counterpoint to the investment of private and public money in urban revitalisation without good dialogue with local leaders. There was no investment whatsoever in the locality where the Pedra do Sal heritage site stands, nor in the Valongo Wharf itself, during the Olympic mega-event — the works on the Boulevard Olímpico were restricted to one main street and Praça Mauá.

Even so, as stated earlier, given that it was a year of reconciliations, our proposal was not a direct affront. Rather, the strategy was to win international attention for the demands of artists and quilombolas regarding Afro-Brazilian representation in the port district, in order to give visibility to the local historical importance. That is why we entitled the project "Sankofa", an Adinkra pictogram that represents a bird looking backwards while moving forwards; it means learning from the past in order to live the future. To date the project has been publicised in a 2-minute video by the AlJazeera Plus network, reaching approximately 500,000 views, as well as in a video report by the South African broadcaster ENCA and in some other written pieces. Some of the reports highlighted the politicised action of artists; others were more interested in explaining the history of the port district and in discussing processes of gentrification. Having achieved such a response, it becomes easier for the quilombo to obtain support from public institutions for its projects in the district, or for the public and private powers to be more attentive to the quilombolas.

In the midst of so many problems, art appears as a diplomatic element, a neutral power that seeks not to reinforce pre-existing tensions while the identity of a group that constantly feels under-represented is strengthened. Is calling the project artistic enough to soften political tensions? How far does that depend on the power groups involved or on the quality of the work? Who will validate the quality of this work? The quilombolas? The international media? Unesco? Art institutions, the art market (so reduced and small in Rio), the foreign or the national press? The people who come for the samba?

And so I end the essay with as many questions as when I began, or more. But at least I am glad that so far the doubts have pushed me to try to understand more, to have more curiosity and will, and not the other way round. The account of the project in Rio contributes to the discussion proposed here by showing how many levels of reading and engagement a visual production can have. If it were assessed only as an artistic work, many of the difficulties and developments essential to the initiative would not be relevant. I would not be able to say whether what we proposed was a political or an artistic intervention, or whether the most important outcome lies in the articulation with the people who use the space of Pedra do Sal or in the play of powers that comes about when we start dealing with the international media in order to put pressure on the actions of local government. And when one thinks about the power of the media, having a good understanding of marketing may be more useful than having a well-elaborated artistic concept — something I note with a certain sadness. That is to say, to judge the project's relevance only by the parameters of the art world would be limiting.

Notes

¹: "Por primera vez en la historia, tenemos un medio global que los usuarios pueden determinar tanto como sus productores." — The author's own free translation, p. 72. in DUSSEL, Inés. *Entrevista con Nicholas Mirzoeff: La cultura visual contemporánea: política y pedagogía para este tiempo*. Propuesta Educativa, Buenos Aires: v. 31, p. 69–79, 2015.

²: BLUMEN, Felipe. *O Píxo e o que tem de mais conceitual na arte contemporânea hoje* [Píxo and what is most conceptual in contemporary art today]. in Catraca Livre, website. Available at: <https://catracalivre.com.br/sp/arte-e-design/indicacao/o-pixo-e-o-que-tem-de-mais-conceitual-na-arte-contemporanea-hoje/> . Published 22/08/2014, accessed June 2016.

³: DA COSTA, Flavia Carolina. *Morro da Conceição: uma etnografia da sociabilidade e do conflito numa metrópole brasileira* [Morro da Conceição: an ethnography of sociability and conflict in a Brazilian metropolis]. 2010. 100 pp. Dissertation (Master's in Anthropology) – Universidade Federal de São Carlos, São Carlos. 2010.

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